Around the same time that my ulcer disappeared, things had started to turn up for me in Sacramento. Our spending cutbacks and the tax increase had begun to put the state's financial house in order; I was learning a little more about how to deal with a hostile legislature; I was learning how valuable the line-item veto, the governor's authority to veto individual items in a budget proposal, can be when you're dealing with an unfriendly legislature; and I was learning probably the most important political lesson of my years in Sacramento: the value of taking my case to the people.

Although the Democrats controlled the legislature, it occurred to me that I had an opportunity to go over their heads. Franklin D. Roosevelt gave me the idea with his Fireside Chats, which made an indelible mark on me during the Depression.

By going on television or radio and telling the people what was going on in Sacramento and what we were trying to do about it, I thought I might be able to get public opinion on my side.

It worked better than I ever dreamed it would.

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During eight years of travels for General Electric and during the campaign for governor, I'd gotten a good idea of what was on the minds of people. They wanted their government to be fair, not waste their money, and intrude as little as possible in their lives. A lot of people in Sacramento had different ideas of what government should be and I told the people that.

I discovered that if you could make the public understand what was going on, they'd do the rest: They'd write letters or call their assemblymen and senators and apply pressure on them. The legislators knew that sooner or later they'd have to face voters again, and as I suspected, there was a